The Road Less TRAVELLED

If you can't bear the thought of getting wet, Nubra's precipitation-free, high-altitude desert setting may be just the thing for you



AT ONE WITH NATURE
Sundowners at the Sumur Sand Dunes in Nubra

It took me a long time to get to Nubra. By the time I made my way here, it was reeling under the weight of over-tourism, the once-storied road across the Khardung La to the 'Valley of Flowers', a non-stop traffic jam of wannabe Hell's Angels and tourists in balaclavas who dropped like flies in the rarefied air of one of the highest motorable passes in the world.

Luckily, I had been tipped off; so, instead of turning left at the fork where the Nubra and Shyok rivers meet and heading into the tourist traps of Diskit and Hunder, I took a right. The road less travelled took me to the village of Teggar, lying on the banks of the Nubra River, where Rigzin Wangtak Kalon—whose prominent land-owning family has historical ties to Nubra stretching back several generations—has created the Lchang Nang Retreat, an eco-conscious boutique property that walks the talk when it comes to sustainable tourism practices. The solar-powered retreat with spacious and tastefully appointed cottages—and running hot water—has been created with low-impact, local construction materials like mud and rock for the walls and willow and poplar for the roofs.

Nubra's bleak and surreal landscape of scattered rock and towering crag can be unsettling at first. The light at 10,000 feet hits different too. Staying at Lchang Nang softened the blow and the valley grew on me. Next morning, I had a sumptuous breakfast by the river, its summer flow heavy with silt. A tributary of the Shyok, it's also called the Siachen River and originates from that glacier. The road that runs along it goes all the way to the Siachen Base Camp, now open to tourists. On the way lies the leafy village of Panamik,